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Sacred cites: Engaging the spiritual in ethnographic knowledge (re)production

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Abstract

In this article I offer a Black feminist sacred citational praxis supported by considerations of how subjectivity, relationality, and epistemology speak to questions, such as: which voices contribute to the stories we tell, the arguments that we make, and what is our responsibility to marking and naming those voices? Certainly, the calling of academic names, those thinkers and scholars recognized in academia largely through peer-reviewed writings, is both commonplace and normative. This includes both people who are living and those who have passed. That is, part of our accepted normal praxis is being in conversation with the dead. Yet largely we don't speak of the "normative" citations as a spiritual practice, or recognize the naming, quoting, and reproducing of people's voices after they have passed on in that vein. What if we did? What would that look like?

Résumé

Dans cet article, je propose une praxis féministe noire de la citation sacrée, soutenue par des considérations sur la façon dont la subjectivité, la relationnalité et l'épistémologie abordent des questions telles que : quelles voix contribuent aux histoires que nous racontons, aux arguments que nous avançons, et quelle est notre responsabilité dans le marquage et la dénomination de ces voix ? Il est certain que l'évocation des noms des universitaires, ces penseurs et ces chercheurs reconnus dans le monde universitaire en grande partie grâce à des écrits évalués par des pairs, est à la fois banale et normative. Il s'agit aussi bien de personnes vivantes que de personnes décédées. En d'autres termes, une partie de notre praxis normale acceptée consiste à converser avec les morts. Pourtant, dans une large mesure, nous ne parlons pas des citations "normatives" comme d'une pratique spirituelle, et nous ne reconnaissons pas dans cette veine le fait de nommer, de citer et de reproduire les voix des personnes décédées. Et si nous le faisions ? À quoi cela ressemblerait-il ?

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Mot-sclés
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> Black feminist citational praxis is one of the major interventions
> Black women scholars make in the academy.
> (Williams, 2022: 199)

(Oluorogbo urges me, "Speak your truth")

I was holding my book when the block dissolved.

"To Oluorogbo, the scribe and educationist of the Yoruba people.
The Orisha of divine intellect, the one who draws our pictures so that
Obatala could mold us, so that Olodumare could put life in us.
We ask for your blessings, and we ask for your guidance."
(Chief Alagba Baba Erinfolami, quoted in Castor, 2017: 73)

I copied down the quote as I had been trained to do, first writing down the citation as: (Castor, 2017: 73). And then I did a double-take and checked myself. Those words that I quoted were not mine! The prayer they came from was written and delivered by Chief Alagba Baba Erinfolami in his opening ritual for a 2012 conference, held by the Ile Eko Sango/Osun Mil'osa shrine in Trinidad. As I quoted Baba for this article arguing for a sacred citational praxis I found myself asking: Did his voice, his personhood, not deserve to be called, named, and credited? Did he not deserve a citation back then, and even more immediately now? Everything in me answered "yes." And with that my writing block dissolved. Blocks actually. A colleague's question that I had been wrestling with came to mind. They had asked me, during the development of this article, how a sacred citation praxis would improve an ethnographic narrative. Suddenly, I not only had an answer to this question, but the even more pressing issue of my writer's block was also lifted! This experience gifted me with a critical argument that the other facets explored here will support: sacred citational praxis in Black feminist ethnography of religion (and perhaps other genres) offers an antidote to writer's block. Or as Alexander's reflection put another way, "Writer's block, like alienation—or rather, writer's block as an aspect of

Figure 1. Oba Orishagbunrin Ifamoroti Awotunji, one of Oluorogbo's chief priests, hands me a glass of *oti* (gin) to drink as a form of libation following our prayers.Oluorogbo shrine, Ile-Ife, Nigeria, 2014. Photo by Taiwo Thompson.

alienation—is a spiritual problem requiring a spiritual solution" (2006: 320). And as is the way for me with all things spiritual this solution began with the ancestors.

Arriving here hasn't been easy. Putting these words down on paper so that they can be read by you (the reader) and so that they can convey an idea into the world making them a form of *pwen*, aka an altar-punto (Lara, 2020; see chapter 2, esp. p. 27, fn 79) has happened in the face of challenges across many levels—across mind, body, and spirit. Conceived and sketched out in the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic and in the wake of the public extrajudicial murder of George Floyd (may his spirit rest in perfect peace and power), my mind was both inspired and daunted at bringing the concept of a sacred citational praxis into the world. After the positive resolution of several health challenges, I found myself facing this project on a spiritual level. Which brings us to Spirit. Here was perhaps the biggest challenge and the biggest blessing. I felt charged with bringing this idea to fruition, by the ancestors (specifically) and by Spirit more generally.[1] Yet the very inspiration caused a crisis for me—I felt that this was so important and there was no room to get it wrong. The challenge was clear, so where comes in the blessing? Enter Oluorogbo, bringing with him his erudition, problem-solving skills, and inspiration.

Who is Oluorogbo? And what role does he have in this offering of a sacred citational praxis? Years before its publication, I came to Oluorogbo while working on my first book on transnational African religions and Black power in Trinidad's Ifá/Orisha community as a pathway toward liberation (Castor, 2017). I needed all the support and inspiration in the writing process that I could get (a need that will resonate with many writers, especially those writing their first book). I found myself in Ilé-Ifè (part of now Nigeria), an ancient city foundational to the ethnogenesis of the Yorùbá people (a population of over 30 million people largely living in contemporary Nigeria and surrounding West African countries, with their descendants making up a significant proportion of the African Diaspora, and influencing even more of its cultures and religions) and had the good fortune to be

Figure 2. After prayers and libations, Oba Orishagbunrin Ifamoroti Awotunji clasps my hands in an embodied transmission of sacred energy *(asé)* that seals the prayers. Oluorogbo shrine, Ile-Ife, Nigeria, 2014. Photo by Taiwo Thompson.

Figure 3. Oluorogbo shrine, Ile-Ife, Nigeria, 2014. Photo by N. Fadeke Castor.

brought to the Oluorogbo shrine. There I made traditional offerings of *obi* (kola nut) and *oti* (gin or any clear alcohol) and said prayers for the easing of my writer's block, and the courage and inspiration to write from a voice that was both true to myself, and true to the story that I was charged with telling (see Figures 1 and 2). A cool or *funfun*[2] deity, Oluorogbo is an orisha specific to Ilé-Ifè, where he is venerated as "the savior of the world and the inventor of an ancient esoteric form of writing" (Campbell, 2008: 141; see also Fabunmi, 1969: 9). The outside of the shrine is painted, using dots and lines, in abstract representation of the ancient hieroglyphics that were designed to communicate Oluorogbo's notes and observations of the activities of the orisha in the world (i.e. *aiye*) to the divine (Olodumare; see Figure 3).[3] Oluorogbo is held by Ife indigenes and the wider Yorùbá people as the first writer and known as a scholar and scribe.[4] For me, he became a source of spiritual inspiration that helped bring my book into the world. In fact, after my initial offering I would reach out to him again and again for further aid in my writing. And

it was to Oluorogbo that I turned when encountering a block in the flow of words and ideas that were needed to construct this article and to make its important argument for a sacred citational praxis. Over the many months that I have been working on this piece, it is my conversation with Oluorogbo and his blessing that binds me to this offering, this altar–punto (re Lara, 2020), one where I reflect on the possibility of a sacred citational praxis.

> ("Write from what you know," Oluorogbo tells me)

Which brings me to the process of writing and the writer. In my initial efforts to write this article I tried to be less personal and more "objective" which only amplified the difficulty. As profound as this insight feels to me now, it is also predictable. In my efforts to present an academic writing voice, I tried to take on the very objective distant voice that I critique in arguments here (see the section, "Sacred Citations as Relational"). And the remedy is not to be more "objective" but to be more wholly present in the work on all levels.

This leads me to my next challenge and blessing, when I realized that what I thought of with blankness was actually a block. I am returning to the question that arose while workshopping an earlier draft of this article, "Can you think of an ethnographic narrative that would've been improved by sacred citation?," where in response my mind drew a blank.[5] Which is odd as ethnographies are one of my favorite genres to read, especially ethnography of religion. A while later (weeks actually) as I wrestled with revisions, after praying with Oluorogbo it occurred to me that the mental blank was actually a mental block. And that was when I realized the answer was literally staring me in my face. The answer was clear. My own ethnography, *Spiritual Citizenship* (2017), would have been the better for an engagement with a more robust sacred citational praxis. And as these things often happen, when you have a moment (transitory, though it is) of alignment—everything fell into place.

This project for a sacred citational praxis started in the middle of an ongoing dialogue with my great-aunt Ivy Walke about culture in the Caribbean.[6] These conversations in person took place over many years when she was in her 90s. Emerging from one of those conversations on stick-fighting in Trinidad were some notes that she wrote out for me in long hand (Walke, 2009). I found those notes years later and referenced them in an essay that I was developing from a conference paper (Castor, n.d.). As I worked on this I wondered, what was the best way to note and respect her contribution? This question remained in the back of my mind as I continued to be in conversation with Aunt Ivy as she whispered in my ear (by then an ancestor). Surely, I thought her voice deserves to be named in my work and take her place alongside other academic luminaries in that roll call of knowledge production that is the practice of citations? I offer this article as a response not only to this question but to others that have arisen as I went down this path.

What is our responsibility to marking and naming those voices on this journey to a sacred citational praxis? I contend that we explore the question of which voices contribute to the stories we tell and the arguments that we make. The calling of academic names is both commonplace and normative, those thinkers and scholars recognized in academia largely through peer-reviewed writings. This includes both people who are living and those who have passed. In our scholarship we are already talking to the dead. Part of our

accepted normal praxis is being in conversation with the dead.[7] Yet largely, we don't speak of the "normative" citations as a spiritual practice, or recognize the naming, quoting, and reproducing of people's voices, after they have passed on in that vein. What if we did? "Sacred Cites" takes up this challenge through an exploration of a sacred citational praxis as *relational* (195; thanks Savannah [Shange], 2022); and as a "*mark of subjectivity*" (21; thanks Christen [Smith] and Dominique [Garrett-Scott], 2021); and "as a form of *epistemological relatedness*" that point both backward and forward (217, thanks Kathryn [Mariner], 2022). [8,9] In the conclusion, I offer some considerations toward a Manual of Style of the Sacred.

The central impetus for this article was how to align my citational praxis with my Black feminist teachings and my own positionality as a critical ethnographer of religion, which both carry with them respect for the ancestral obligations that are held by the community. My response focuses, through musings and ruminations, on the importance of attending to the often unspoken and unmarked dimensions of knowledge production that in their immateriality are often viewed as non-material—here meant in its sense of without meaning or import. In fact, I build on Savannah Shange's call for us to engage with "citation as a practice of relation" (2022: 195) to argue the opposite (of the non-material as being without meaning): the communications of immaterial subjectivity and agential presences are important and foundational elements of knowledge production. These are critical to a Black feminist praxis that asks us to name those that have become before us, on whose shoulders we stand. "Naming demands that we ask about the unnamed and honor the unnamable" (McKittrick, 2020: 31). And as such they should not only be marked in the text but should be clearly cited.

> (As I write, my head turns to the left and I gaze into the shrine room, checking on Oluorogbo as if to ask: "Am I getting this right?" In the sense of, am I doing right by your presence in this room and in this writing?)

Points of departure

I write this article from my positionality as a Black feminist ethnographer and conjure woman; indeed, as a self-declared conjure feminist (see Brooks et al., 2021).[10] My journey to considering the importance of citing sacred knowledge spans decades and includes many voices and stories, notably those of my ancestors, elders, and Oluorogbo. Academically, Barbara Christian's "The race for theory" (1998) and M. Jacqui Alexander's *Pedagogies of Crossing* (2005) have been inspiring critical interlocutors. Just as my relations with loved ones, community members, and the spiritual realm have taught me to push beyond inherited forms of making and marking knowledge production, so did Alexander's research assistant Kitsimba, in *Pedagogies of Crossing* (who passed through the door of no return circa 1780 from old Kongo to the Caribbean), whose "emergence is pedagogy in its own right: to instruct us on the perilous boundary-keeping between the Sacred and the secular" (2005: 6–7). Their interactions inform not only the project but also its method, asking us, "to take seriously the dimensions of spiritual labor that make the sacred and the disembodied palpably tangible and, therefore, constitutive of the lived experience of millions of women and men in different parts of

the world" (Alexander, 2005: 7). I propose for this new method that "spiritual labor" is an important and often unrecognized contribution to—and indeed a form of—knowledge production. How then to address this missing lacuna in our Black feminist citational praxis? What would it mean to place Kitsimba's name in both the footnotes and in the references alongside those of Mohanty and Lorde? And how would we do so?

> (I turn to look at that place where Oluorogbo's energies are gathered, asking, is this ok? Am I doing justice to your voice? To your inspiration?)

My thinking on this is in conversation with the *Cite Black Women* project (see: https://www.citeblackwomencollective.org/ and The Cite Black Women Collective's "Cite black women: A critical praxis (a statement)" Smith et al., 2021). I start with the premise, shared by the other authors in this special issue, that citational practices matter. They matter because they shape the story that we tell (whose voices are marked and seen); they situate us in a field and a community (how do I position myself and who do I see myself in conversation with?); and they help to create the authority of those who often become gatekeepers (who then is the authority—the go-to person on this topic?). And at a more instrumentalist level citations very much inform who gets tenure, faculty positions, professorships, and promotions. "The academy has traditionally used authorship to create hyper-individualistic hierarchies of knowledge that can be monetized and catalogued according to capitalist and neoliberal measurements" (Smith et al., 2021: 10). The importance of citations in ensuring jobs and job security was recently addressed in publications, specific to the intellectual labor of Black women in anthropology (Smith and Garrett-Scott, 2021) and medical anthropology (Davis and Mulla, 2023), that highlight the importance and impact of particular voices being left out of citations.

I am interested in exploring citation as ritual, even as the pragmatic and instrumental levels of citation remain important. Savannah Shange tells us that "Citation is ceremony, and a bibliography is an altar—a literary libation invoking the ancestors of the word, honoring those who make it possible for the text to emerge. Textual citation calls forth the names of both the living and the dead, crafting a horizontal genealogy of those with whom we share mitochondrial markers of meaning" (2022: 194). From her I borrow the term "literary libation" as a practice, a method, and a praxis of Black feminist knowledge production that allows, even encourages me, to ask: Who/what are the active agents, the subjects that we recognize as producing knowledge? This question is on the level of ontology and epistemology—what category of being do we recognize and name and how do we organize that information or communication as knowledge? For example, how do you cite a dream? How do you cite information that comes from an ancestor? Or knowledge that is received by direct communication with Spirit? After exploring "literary libations" as a sacred citational praxis in terms of subjectivity, relationality, and epistemology I offer some possibilities for a sacred citational format in the conclusion..

Sacred citation as subjectivity

In this article, I take as given that one of the main attributions Black feminist scholars make in the academy is our citational praxis (Williams, 2022: 199). In the spirit of this

(and with permission from and the support of my Black feminist ancestors), I make this offering with its literary libations to ask that when we show up in the academy, we make visible, and give credit to, all of us. With the understanding that "Citation—the process of crediting ideas and inspiration to their source—is not only the measure of 'success' in the academy; it is also the mark of subjectivity" (Smith and Garrett-Scott, 2021: 21), my engagements here extend from my published work on multiple subjectivities where I argue that the reckoning of spirit as active agents expands our conception of subjectivity and intersubjectivity (Castor, 2022). I ask here that we not only make room but center those streams of knowledge and inspiration that come to us from (for sake of a better term) spiritual or celestial realms. What would these encompass? Dreams, yes. Divination, for sure. Communications from Spirit during possession, indeed. For my purposes these are all significantly definitive in comparison to the more elusive support we receive through prayers and instance of divine communication offered by the presence of Spirit.

> (Oluorogbo, am I getting this right? I can feel you here with me but what words are my own and what words are your own? How do I account for you in the generation of this text?).

The recognition of my full self that produces knowledge demands a naming and marking of the multiple levels where this happens, from the body (Castor, 2021) to the intersubjectivity that occurs when engaged in community and collectivity, including multiple subjectivities. This sacred citational praxis is one part of a larger project on the implications of recognizing and centering multiple forms of subjectivity, inclusive of the sacred. The imperative to credit all of the interlocutors in that rich conversation that informs our writing for me is the next step in this unfolding project of mapping a liberatory pathway to the otherwise,[11] or in other terms, developing a decolonial praxis at the epistemic and ontological level (Avalos, 2021).[12] In the current moment, much of revival in attention to the politics of citational praxis owes its provenance to feminist and Black feminist scholars who found that "Black women have been systematically unnamed" and responded with the recognition that "naming is an act of rebellion" (Smith et al., 2021: 10).[13] My provocation here is intended as an act of naming that makes visible the often invisible contributions of the intangibles to Black women's knowledge production that stem from their sacred and spiritual practices.

The spiritual labor of my Black feminist praxis asks us to consider the imperative to bring our whole selves to the spaces that we occupy; to those places where we belong. If citation is labor, as Mariner suggests, "Citation sutures a subject to a voice, a person to (a) work (citation is labor—see citation is capital below)" then what of spiritual labor (2022: 216)? The "intellectual polity" is one space where we bring out spiritual labor (Smith and Garrett-Scott, 2021: 24). As a self-named conjure woman I offer that bringing my whole self into the domain of knowledge production (a project of many Black feminists) calls for incorporating those non-human powers, also known as intangibles, who have contributed to our categories, knowledge, and intellectual projects. What are the implications of closely writing with other voices? There's a way that this article is an extension of "subjectivity" (2022) in terms of reflecting, in different registers, on the implications of taking seriously the agency of Spirit (what some call "intangibles,"

"entities," and "other-than-human powers" or "non-human powers" (Castor, 2022: 75, 77; see also Crosson, 2019: 550). If then we are to take seriously the "agency of intangibles" (Blanes and Santo, 2014: 30) and that they are subjects that contribute to our writing and to our work in conjunction with citational praxis being a "mark of subjectivity" should they then not be recognized? Put another way, is there an ethical imperative to recognizing and citing those who contribute to our work? If there is, as I argue here, then don't we also have an obligation to not only give the "intangibles" or Spirit or ancestors credit in a form of notation that marks their presence in and contribution to our body of knowledge? If citations serve to recognize and map all the voices that we are in conversation with then I posit that we should include those voices of "other-than-human" powers that inform our knowledge production as part of a Black feminist praxis of the sacred. And in doing so, we build a more complete epistemic map of our relations.

Sacred citation as relational

My reflections on how sacred citations incorporate different subjectivities ask that we contemplate how those different subjects are linked, how they relate, and how they are in relation. I have been helped in this by Savannah Shange's beautiful, important, and compelling article, "Citation as ceremony: #SayHerName, #CiteBlackWomen, and the practice of reparative enunciation" (2022) where she elucidates "citation as a practice of *relation*" (2022: 195; author's emphasis).[14] Building on Shange's offering I start with her proposition that, "Careful, ethical ethnography *cites* our research participants as thought and theory partners in the effort to speak back to the silences and violences of extant social science. Citation, then, can function as a mode of Black relation, in which the writer releases the Enlightenment lie of sole authorship to embrace the polyphonous nature of the ethnographic text" (2022: 194; author's emphasis). Grounded in a Black feminist praxis this calls for a decentering of our knowledge production and authorship from a singular all-knowing subject toward a vision of collectivity and multiplicity (see also, Harrison, 2022). I hear resonances with Katherine McKittrick's recent work where she calls for our praxis of references to be "about how we radically reimagine liberation collectively" (2020: 31). Ethnography, and specifically (but not exclusively) ethnography of religion, provides us a genre in both method and form that lends itself to collective knowledge production through its "polyphonous nature," which then needs a corresponding citational praxis; one where all voices that contribute can be named, credited, and included in the conversation. And it is through our formulation of an inclusive and polyphonic sacred citational praxis that we build and strengthen our relations, which in turn informs our construction of collectives where we can imagine (and reimagine) liberation.

(Oluorogbo, I give thanks for your presence and am grateful to be in relation with you)

Citations map our relations with others. And part of our being in relation is being in relation with multiple subjectivities across different positionalities and manifestations. What I mean here is that "relation" for me is a decentering of the subject that also displaces singularity. To be in 'relation' is to be connected to another, to have a connection, that is "intersubjective (having a shared consciousness)" with something outside of

self—be that land, animal, ancestor, Spirit, family, or more generally, other people (Avalos, 2021: 84). To be in relation is to be in community, the kind of community that Jafari Allen points to as "compounded kin spaces of sociality" (2022: 29). These spaces of sociality are often made and found in ritual spaces that are occupied by multiple forms of being(s). Reflecting on the question of how a sacred citational praxis could add to an ethnographic narrative I think of my recounting of Oshun's gathering of people at the start of an Ifá conference as one place where a sacred citational praxis would have been helpful. Oshun was named in the text but also needed to have her voice and her contribution to the knowledge of the book named in the bibliography as a form of literary libation (Oshun quoted in Castor, 2017: ch. 5; see especially 128, 160).

It is this formulation of relation that I recognize and ground in a Conjure Feminism where work on "Black women's knowledge production" conjures "a Black feminist way of being human, defined not by Western individualism but by intergenerational relationships and deep connections to Black ancestors, ancestral traditions, and the afterlife" (Brooks, Martin, and Simmons, 2021: 452, 458). In "Conjure feminism: Toward a genealogy" (2021) the authors introduce their special issue asking for the recognition and centering of ancestral knowledge. "What have we inherited from Conjure Feminists Queen Nanny, Marie Laveau, Tituba, and the Grandmamas, Mambos, and Madrinas for whom Western history does not hold space?" (Brooks et al., 2021: 455). It is these ancestors, and many more, whose voices demand and deserve to not only be named and called in our personal spiritual practices but to be recognized and referenced in the spiritual labor that informs our knowledge production.

With this I have come full circle back to Savannah Shange's formulation of citation as a spiritual practice, in full agreement that it is a practice of relation. And one that reaches across temporalities. "As a form of epistemological relatedness, citations point: backward and sometimes forward" (Mariner, 2022: 217). In that relationality, that weaves and circles across linear temporalities, we engage through the power of the word with a multitude of subjectivities. In the present-past-future that Lara invokes in their ofrenda[15] *Queer Freedom: Black Sovereignty* (2020) there is an Afro-diasporic informed temporality where when we cite people who are still on this material plane (body-land is Lara's formulation) there is also an engagement with spirit. My ask here in the spirit of relationality is that we consider a responsibility to extend citational praxis to those subjectivities that are differently manifest—that is as entities, loa, divine presences, ancestors, or even whispers from our dreams. And to some extent we are already (partially) doing this work as our current citational practices weave together a conversation of knowledge production that brings together the living and the dead.

To lay the groundwork for a method of marking intangible contributions I return to an earlier observation. When we quote the work of scholars who have transitioned then we are engaging them and are in relation to spirit. As Jafari Allen attests in his own work, "This ethnography of an idea emerges in conversation with those with whom I stand shoulder to shoulder (and shoulders joined to the hoe!) across miles and seas and continents, listening to and in conversation, still, with our dead" (2022: xi). This testament of relationality ("stand shoulder to shoulder") extends across realms and temporalities to also be "in conversation, still, with our dead." For Allen this praxis unfolds throughout the text through an intimacy that brings together conversation partners from scholars to musicians to activists

"shoulder to shoulder" with his musings, reflections, and theorizations toward an "ethnography of an idea" (2022: xi). This exemplar of being in relation, of being in community, of relationality, sits at the core of a Black feminist praxis where we do not know ourselves, heal, or create outside of being in relation, and being in community.[16]

If as Shange prompts us, we are releasing the lie of the singular author in exchange for an "embrace [of the] polyphonous nature of the ethnographic text" then what is our method for remembering, marking, and naming those many voices that inform our ethnographic writings, especially those grounded in Black feminist praxis and evocative of (or drawing on) spiritual and religious expressions (2022: 194)? Sparked by the generous and intimate voice that Jafari Allen offers us in *There's a Disco Ball between Us* (2022) I am musing over the opaque line between who is here with us and who is not.[17] For example, when I was writing my book *Spiritual Citizenship* (2017) the voices of friends, elders, and Spirit were all intertwined while most (not all) of them were embodied in a material manifest way of corporeal "presence" that we associate with being "alive." A few months after the book's publication, Chief Alagba Erinfolami, a central voice that runs throughout the narrative, transitioned to the ancestral realm. And, from there he continues to inspire and motivate me, offering his support. How do I cite the shifting engagements with a subjectivity whose contributions are in conversation with me and inform aspects of my knowledge production across shifting temporalities and realms? My proposal to this question is a sacred citational praxis where in offering literary libations we name those intangible subjects that we are in relation with who contribute to our thinking, to our writing, and to our production of knowledge.

Sacred citation as epistemology

As noted, the early thoughts for this piece have been germinating for decades from the seeds planted by Barbara Christian's "The Race for Theory" (1988), which though published an astonishing thirty-five years ago remains a needed intervention. Speaking of Black people (and more specifically, Black women) Christian offered, "My folk, in other words, have always been a race for theory—though more in the form of the hieroglyph, a written figure that is both sensual and abstract, both beautiful and communicative" (1988: 68). Perhaps we can consider that one dimension of "the hieroglyph" has been (always and still) the intangible, those communiques from Spirit, the living presence of our ancestors, and that these communiques are an important part of our epistemological project. And if, as Katherine McKittrick argues, citations are "a tool for racial liberation" (2020, 213) then making room for these intangibles and marking their space, noting them, giving credit and taking it one step further by citing them, feels like an important step in an epistemology of liberation. It feels right.

Who we are, as subjects and in community, as a collectivity informs both how we encounter and make sense of the world. Considerations of how we construct knowledge, a project central to any citational praxis, pulls forward the arguments from previous sections on the power of multiple subjectivities and the central position that relationality occupies for the project of liberation. M. Jacqui Alexander casts a light on the guiding horizon for this work when she pronounces, "This, then, is the existential message of the Crossing—to apprehend how it might instruct us in the urgent task of configuring new

ways of being and knowing and to plot the different metaphysics that are needed to move away from living alterity premised in difference to living intersubjectivity premised in relationality and solidarity" (2015: 8–9). In this quote they bring together the heart of the matter for a liberatory praxis, "configuring new ways of being and knowing" and position it in collective community. For Alexander (and for so many of us, if not for you dear reader—or maybe for you too?) the experience of the Sacred is a (feminist) epistemic category (2015: 294–95). And put together with a construction of "spiritual work as a type of body praxis, as a form of embodiment" (2015: 297) there is a clear link of "Black women's epistemic agency" with "the scaffolding of Conjure Feminism—and the meaning and beauty of embodied knowledge" (Brooks et al., 2021: 457). Together these inform a Black feminist centered sacred citational practice, that is both inclusive of multiplicity, orientated toward collectivity, and guided, alongside Katherine McKittrick and Sara Ahmed, toward a liberatory praxis.

McKittrick observes, reflecting on Ahmed's citational praxis, that its importance is located in that "it asks that we think about the epistemological grounds through which we theorize and imagine and name liberation in our referencing practices" (2020: 22). This points to a recuperative practice where we put our attention to referencing that which is building, informing, and inspiring our work. In that spirit this article asks us that we consider what we are already editing out of our citational praxis. What voices have we left unmarked? How can we move beyond the disciplined practices of knowledge production that have us reproducing the "proper" marking of authoritative voices? As we are reminded, "The logics of patriarchal white supremacy determine the politics of knowledge production and consumption, leaving Black scholars on the margins" (Smith and Garrett-Scott, 2021: 23), a marginalization that Barbara Christian responded to some four decades ago when she wrote "The Race to Theory" (1988: see esp. 71). Several scholars have reflected in both qualitative and quantitative terms that this marginalization continues into the present moment. Given that "Citational politics produce social meaning in the academy" (Smith and Garrett-Scott, 2021: 24), then perhaps it is meaningful to not only change *whom* we name in our citational praxis and knowledge production but also *how*, that is the manner in which we cite.

In bringing all the voices that contribute to our knowledge production into the room and on the page a central issue is how we recognize them. In "Sacred Cites" I propose an extension from Bianca Williams's recognition of citing "important contributors to knowledge-making in our texts and presentations" that includes "Community members, friends, students who teach and help us cultivate ideas" (2022: 201–2). As previously established, sacred citational praxes are relational practices that bring into the conversation multiple subjectivities, including those often disembodied voices and non-corporeal communications (be they entities, powers, ancestors, or some other dimension of Spirit). This is bolstered by Williams next point: citation "is about dialoging *with* those you have learned from, marking and valuing the collaborations between your thoughts and their work to create something generative" (2022: 202; author's emphasis). The production of new knowledge, formulation of novel argumentation, and other goals of our writing practices are largely the extension of ongoing conversations. And in these dialogues are the "polyphonic voices" of our own inner and intersubjectivity, our colleagues, our families, and community members. Indeed, not only those people that Williams called at the opening of this paragraph but also extending this to include our ancestors (familial,

spiritual, and academic—I'm calling Audre Lorde in here) and other presences from the spiritual realm (here I'm calling Oluorogbo). While I've made this point elsewhere in this article, I want to emphasize here the importance of expanding the voices named (and we already touched on the power of naming) into the generative process of knowledge production. I offer that in the inclusive marking, making visible, and naming of literary libations we are building a more holistic space of meaning creation where we can bring in more of our whole selves, which serve to center the "hieroglyph" of our knowing and conjuring selves. And in doing so, I posit, we can create more generative ways of writing that can then map our ways into "configuring new ways of being and knowing" (Alexander, 2015: 8–9).

Conclusion: Toward a Manual of Style for the Sacred

"Sacred Cites" is one answer to the call to consider the possibilities of not only naming the unnamed but to bring those newly named voices into the technology of knowledge reproduction that is citational praxis. On the face of it this might seem either provocative (how do knowledge sources not accessible to everyone take a place in our citations?) or trivial (what does it matter if the voices of the intangible are recognized in knowledge production?). I contend that this sacred citational praxis is neither. Through a series of reflections in the previous sections I conveyed that this task is in alignment with the bringing together of metaphysics with novel ontologies and epistemologies grounded in relationality (Alexander, 2015: 8–9). Some of the voices that I brought into this conversation are embodied in the present moment while others are intangible. As such, some of the voices may have been more familiar (Barbara Christian, Savannah Shange, Katherine McKittrick, Christen Smith, Bianca Williams) while others have been less so (Aunt Ivy, Oluorogbo), reflecting the proposed method that brings the voices of our spiritual labor into the broader intellectual polity. In this larger project of "configuring new ways of being and knowing" I have found the act and practice of naming to be central to a project where we, as voiced by McKittrick, "radically reimagine liberation collectively," underscoring the relevancy of voices that so often go unnamed to "the work" and our knowledge production (Alexander 2006: 7–8; McKitrrick 2020: 31).

Questions arise when I think through the citing of sacred communication of not only "should I" but "how would I?" They lead me to ask, What are the possibilities and limits in the *Chicago Manual of Style* (CMOS) to the field "personal communication" and how does that reflect back on our assumptions and presumptions around knowledge production? Alluded to earlier in the introduction, if accessibility is an issue—we cite in part so that others can follow that reference—what does it mean to cite sources that are inaccessible to the reader? Yet, what of accessibility in ethnographic sources? When I cite personal communication from an elder in Trinidad the academic conceit is to accept the authority of that source even if the reader doesn't have access to either that person or any recording of said conversation. How different is it then if I cite a conversation that I had with that elder once they have moved into the ancestral realm? Or for that matter a communication and/or divination with Oluorogbo (in a format where the orisha are said to speak through *obi* (kola nut), cowries, or other divinatory instruments)? I want to propose that we extend the "personal communication" entry of CMOS that is used in ethnographic writing (among other places) to encompass communication with the Sacred. What would that look like?

Consider a template for a Manual of Style for the Sacred (MSS) as an extension of the CMOS (17th edition) from section 15.53, "Unpublished interviews and personal communications" in Author-Date References, where they advise,

> In a parenthetical citation, the terms *personal communication* (or *pers. comm.*), *unpublished data*, and the like may be used after the name(s) of the person(s) concerned, following a comma. If the medium is important and not mentioned in the text, it may be incorporated into the parenthetical reference. Reference list entries are unneeded, though each person cited must be fully identified elsewhere in the text. Initials may be used for first names. Unless it is mentioned in the text, a date should be added in parentheses, following a comma. The abbreviation *et al.* should be avoided in such citations. (2017; sources emphases)

An important place where the MSS differs from CMOS is with regards to the reference list. Whereas CMOS says that listing personal communication in reference lists is "unneeded" the MSS strongly recommends listing these in references. Given all the arguments made here on the power of naming, in recognizing a different way of being in the world, and making knowledge I argue that it is essential that personal communications be included in the list of references or bibliography (as I have done in this text). One model for this template comes from Lorisia MacLeod's work on citing Indigenous Elders and knowledge keepers.[17] Their project of "how academia can make small changes to improve the respectful recognition of Indigenous knowledge and voices" documented the 2018 work at NorQuest College (in partnership with the NorQuest Indigenous Student Centre) to create templates for "citing Indigenous oral traditions" (1). While focused on extending APA and MLA formats they have several features which are useful for a MSS.[18] I propose the following adaption of CMOS and MacLeod:

> Lastname, Firstname. Community. Topic/subject of communication as applicable. personal communication OR form of communication, Month Date, Year.

Examples include the following (future variations and revisions should expand and build on these):

- Communication with an ancestor:

> Walke, Ivy. Ancestral realm. On stickfighting in Trinidad. Through divination, March 23, 2023.

- Communication with a spirit:

> Oluorogbo. Ile-Ife lineage. Advice and encouragement on writing. Through prayer, January 21, 2023.

In lieu of specifics, based on the context of the communication and preference of the author, a shorter (and vaguer) format could be followed in also line with CMOS template for personal communication. By example where CMOS says,

> "(Julie Cantor, pers. comm.)
> (Jonathan Lee, Facebook direct message to author, May 5, 2017)
> (Brenda Hasbrouck, text message to author, May 5, 2017)" (2017, §15.53)

I propose the following MSS versions:

> (Oluorogbo, prayer and divination, January 10, 2023)
> (Oluorogbo, pers. comm.)
> (Ivy Walke, divinatory message to author, March 23, 2023)

This offering of a sacred citational praxis is made as a form of literary libation that reflects the spiritual labor of Black conjure women and their Black feminist praxis. In putting forth this libation I have proposed a new citational method. This important spiritual, citational, and intellectual labor not only expands our terrain of knowledge production but also offers an approach to the writer's block that so often plagues me (and many other writers) as they attempt to craft narrative's that map Black and Indigenous ways of knowing that go against the grain of hegemonic Euro-American systems of knowledge production. In closing let me give Katherine McKittrick the last word, underscoring the importance of a sacred citational praxis as shield and rebuke to systems of anti-Blackness.

> Citation would, then, perhaps be considered one fulcrum of black studies: in a world that despises blackness the bibliography—written or sung or whispered or remembered or dreamed or forgotten—ushers in, or initiates, or teaches, or affirms. This is the praxis of being black and human as struggle. This cites and sites a genre of humanness that emerged from but is *not solely* defined by plantocratic logics of dispossession: the works cited, what we tell each other about what we know and how to know, contain *how* to refuse practices of dehumanization. (2020: 26–27; author's emphasis)

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Notes

1. My larger argument, while grounded in this system, is meant to be applicable to a wider range of faith traditions and expressions of the divine rooted in many Indigenous and African religious practices. Spirit is an energy and communication of the divine that manifests for me through the system of Yorùbá Isese L'agba, aka Ifá/Orisha. Note that I capitalize Spirit when referring to an expression of the divine, commonly recognized as deific or spectral. On the other hand, when talking in general or possessive I use the lowercase, e.g., "my spirit was bolstered by their support."
2. Funfun, is a Yorùbá term that, "includes grays, white, cream, sky blue, silver and shimmering transparencies" (Campbell 2008: 42). For more on color in Yoruba cosmology see chapter 2 in Bolaji Campbell's *Painting for the Gods: Art and Aesthetics of Yoruba Religious Murals* (2008).
3. See Campbell (2008) for an elaboration on the symbolic meanings of these and other paintings on the Oluorogbo shrine in Ilé-Ifè, Nigeria, pp. 137–143.
4. In the Ifá odu Oyeku l'ogbe he is celebrated as "'Oluorogbo, the messenger of peace between heaven and earth, on the eve of collapse of Ife, Oluorogbo averted the danger of destruction.' *Oluorogbo-iko ajalaye iko. Ajalorun: oku dede ki aye olufe baje, ni Oluorogbo ba wa tun aye se*" (Eluyemi [1985] quoted in Campbell, 2008: 137; see also Bascom, 1991 [1969]: 228–231).
5. I extend my gratitude to Elizabeth Pérez for her insightful and generative question.
6. Ivy Carmen Walke (b. 1913–d. 2011) was an independent business woman, Honorary Vice-Consul to Mexico, and a founding member of La Petite Musical (a renowned folk music group in Trinidad founded and led by her sister Olive Walke). She was both a product of her time and ahead of it. I was fortunate enough to live in Trinidad during the last decade of her life when we got to know each other and become close.
7. I use the term "the dead" here as not all people who have passed from this world are ancestors in general or my ancestors specifically. In this text when talking of the ancestors I am talking about either people in my direct genealogical lineage who passed after a long life well lived or about "affinity" ancestors—those people whose lives have made an impact and left a legacy that resonates with me at the level of both my spirit and my work.
8. While these three areas are my focus here, they are not the only dimensions of a sacred citational praxis.
9. I borrow this rhetorical strategy of engaging scholars by their first name from the recent inspiration of Jafari Allen in his work, *There's a Disco Ball between Us* (2022) where in the context of being in conversation with many people, including "listening to and in conversation, still, with our dead," he says that, "By citing first names, I am attempting to reflect and invite the intimacy of invested conversation between intellectual forbearers/ancestors, colleagues, and/or friends (and indeed those who are friends only in the head of the author)" (xi). Note that this praxis is conveyed by Jafari with a caveat of close engagements with their work, respect, and intimacy. I engage in this praxis here in this spirit.
10. The liminality of being a child of the diaspora informs many of my multiple positionalities (Trini, American, red, Black) and multiple subjectivities (inclusive of all the spiritual energies whose àṣẹ I have been crowned with: Ifá, Obatala, Ẹgbẹ́ Ọ̀run, and others).
11. My use of the term "otherwise" indicates both our very heterodox positionalities within our current modernity (thinking here with Trouillot's "otherwise modern," 2002: 225 and

Crawley, 2017: 6–7) and the possibility of new socialities and systems rooted in liberation emerging from conversations at the intersection of Native American and Indigenous Studies and Black Studies (see King et al., 2020).

12. Here I'm thinking with Natalie Avalos, specifically where she asks that "if we think of decolonization as mediated by the immaterial then maybe we should think in terms of metaphysical sovereignty as well—a kind of sovereignty that is not just geopolitical but is rooted in intersubjective relationships to others, land, cosmos" (2021: 86).
13. Amongst the active and growing scholarship on citations, respect must be paid here to the work of Sara Ahmed (2013) and the #CiteBlackWomen collective, with special note of founder Christen Smith's organizing and publications (with Garret-Scott 2021 and with Williams, Wedud, Pirtle and The Cite Black Women Collective 2021). Their clear charge in Cite Black Women, "We theorize, we innovative, we revolutionize the world" leads to this critical statement, an important point of departure for this article: "It is time to upturn the erasures of history" (2021: 10).
14. I find this evocative of Glissant's *Poetics of Relation*; "the rhizome of a multiple relationship with the Other and basing every community's reasons for existence on a modern form of the sacred, which would be, all in all, a Poetics of Relation" (1997: 16).
15. "Ofrenda means offering. Ofrendas reflect the person's heart and, often, their capacity to demonstrate love, generosity, respect, and reciprocity" (Lara, 2020: 1, fn 1).
16. See Alexander, where highlighting Paulo Freire, she "underscore[s] the fact that shifts in consciousness happen through active processes of practice and reflection. Of necessity, they occur in community" (2006: 283).
17. This voice is reflected throughout Jafari Allen's engaging and successfully ambitious text. See especially fn 23, part III conclusion, 378 for the citation of "Aunt Natalie".
18. I am grateful to Elizabeth Pérez for pointing me to this invaluable resource.
19. They also note a project at the University of British Columbia to adapt the templates to the Chicago format.

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